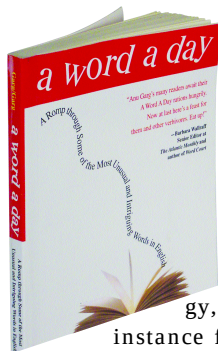




A Word a Day

Sugar-candy for word-o-philics

A *Word a Day (AWAD)* is a slim, attractively-designed volume that will be enjoyed by people who love words for words' sake. It's written by the people behind the Wordsmith Web site. To quote the cover, "It's a romp through some of the most unusual and intriguing words in English". If you are wont to be enchanted by such words as 'zephyr', just for the sound of it and the imagery it evokes, you should buy this book. Or, if you revel in knowing the correct term for something such as 'defenestrate' for 'throw out the window'. Also, if you're the kind that likes to drop a word here and there during a conversation, and then explain it to everyone around, you'll find enough material here.



The book is a collation of the most interesting of the daily e-mails sent to subscribers from www.wordsmith.org. It's organized into interesting sections much like the newsletter—words that make the spell-checker ineffective, words to describe people and so on. A typical page consists, apart from the words and their meanings, of a riot of diversions: etymology, an example of usage, an instance from history where the word was used, a story related to the word and a quote at the bottom of the page. The quote collection is also pretty good, and includes quotes from Nietzsche, Mark Twain and such.

The biggest complaint about *AWAD* is that it's a small book. It doesn't quite cut it as a reference for crossword or etymology enthusiasts—because it only talks about 327 words.

Some of the example usages seem contrived. Also, *AWAD* is not written in a style that is likely to make linguophiles out of techies: it sometimes gives the impression of having been quickly cobbled together from old pieces.

Nevertheless, browsing through it a random page at a time is fun; and when you read it like a regular book, it's a laid-back, breezy stroll through word-nuggets. *AWAD*'s appeal lies in the sense of delighting in words that it gets across. However, there aren't too many who would care for such pleasures, and this makes the book unlikely to be picked up by most of us.

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Video Demystified

A detailed dissection

Understanding video is complex; fortunately *Video Demystified* is a well-researched book, but the array of technical intricacies covered here are just mind-boggling. That's not to say that it should be avoided at all costs, but even for an avid enthusiast, this book is far too extensive. For example, there are more than 20 pages describing and illustrating the technicalities of the different types of test signals used in video.

The book starts with analog and digital video basics, and the real world situations of broadcasting and recording. Standards and formats are discussed in detail with heavy doses of technical specifications and comparisons through tables and diagrams. The chapters covering MPEG video give a good insight

into the way current digital video and compression works.

The amount of technical data it packs makes it good reference book, rather than something you are likely to read end to end. The two CDs included contain a digital version of the text, sample files for testing your video and some other utilities.

But should you read it? If you have an interest in video or would like to experiment with it, this is a good place to get



the basics right and move onto advanced topics. The same topics covered here apply to newer techniques and standards of compression, such as DivX and Windows Media codecs. The understanding of digital video that this book provides will help you get the best out of these technologies. The author knows what he's talking about, but most of us don't want to know all the details. Simple PC-based editing applications

won't even expose you to options for most of the concepts covered here. So, if you just want to edit your first home movie on your brand new PC, give this one a skip.

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